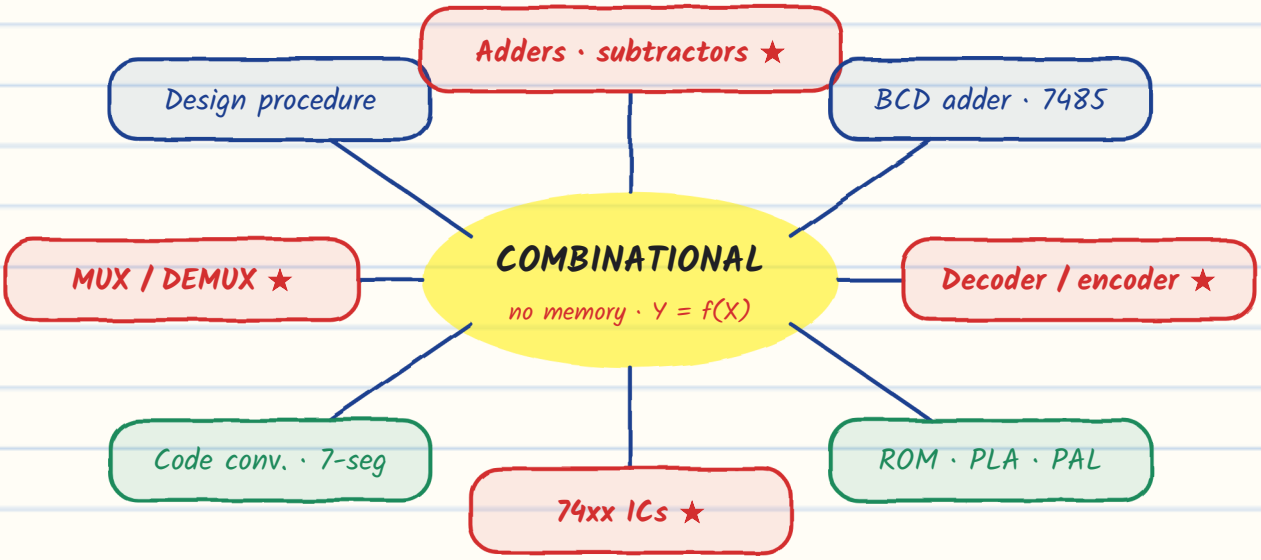
Combinational Circuits

Adders · CLA · BCD · comparator · decoder · MUX · PLA: exam-ready in 11 sheets



↑ the whole topic on one page: red = high-yield, green = applied / programmable

➜ Syllabus coverage

"Digital logic: … combinational logic circuits, minimization techniques; Arithmetic and data handling logic circuits, decoders and encoders, multiplexers and demultiplexers; Combinational circuit design; … PLA design". This notebook covers all of these. Flip-flops and counters are in the Sequential Circuits notes; K-maps are in the Boolean Algebra notes.

High-yield list

① HA / FA equations
② FA = 2 HA + 1 OR
③ CLA: G and P terms
④ n selects → 2^n inputs
⑤ decoder = minterms
⑥ 7483 · 74138 · 74151

Legend yellow = key term · red circle = must-memorise fact · **purple box** = memory trick · **red box** = exam trap · **green** = worked example

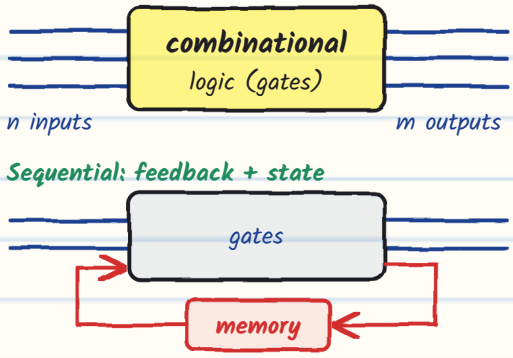
➜ Contents

✓ Basics, design, half adder ..... p. 2
✓ Full adder & subtractors ..... p. 3
✓ Ripple-carry & look-ahead ..... p. 4
✓ Adder-subtractor, BCD, comparator … p. 5
✓ Decoders & encoders ..... p. 6
✓ MUX & DEMUX ..... p. 7
✓ Code converters, parity, 7-seg … p. 8
✓ ROM · PLA · PAL · hazards ..... p. 9
✓ Night-before sheet ..... p. 10
✓ Practice MCQs + written ..... p. 11

1 Combinational vs Sequential

MCQ favourite

Definition A **combinational circuit** is a network of gates whose outputs depend **only on the present inputs**: $Y = f(X)$. No memory, no clock, no feedback. A **sequential** circuit also uses **stored state** (flip-flops) → Sequential Circuits notes.



top: $Y = f(X)$ · bottom: $Y = f(X, \text{state})$

Feature	Combinational	Sequential
Memory	none	flip-flops
Clock	not needed	usually
Feedback	none	yes
Model	truth table	state table
Examples	adder, MUX	counter, register

2 Design Procedure

written favourite

1. Fix the **inputs and outputs**; name them
2. Write the **truth table** (2^n rows; unused codes = X)
3. Simplify each output (K-map, Boolean Algebra sheets 7–8)
4. Draw the circuit (AND-OR → NAND-NAND)
5. Verify a few rows

Worked example ✍️ 3-bit **prime detector**: F = 1 when ABC (A = MSB) is 2, 3, 5 or 7.

$F = \Sigma m(2, 3, 5, 7)$: pairs m2, m3 = **A'B**; m5, m7 = **AC**

$F =$ **A'B + AC** · check 001: 0 ✓

Families **Arithmetic:** adders, subtractors, comparators, ALU · **Data routing:** MUX, DEMUX, decoders, encoders · **Code conversion:** BCD↔XS-3, binary↔Gray, 7-segment · **Error detection:** parity · **Programmable:** ROM, PLA, PAL

3 Half Adder (HA)

high-yield

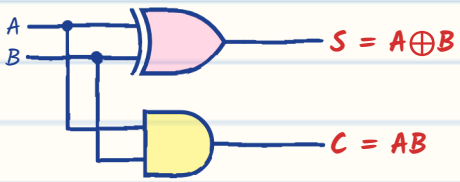
A	B	S	C
0	0	0	0
0	1	1	0
1	0	1	0
1	1	0	1

Adds **two** bits; no carry-in.

Sum $S = A \oplus B$

Carry $C = A \cdot B$

1 XOR + 1 AND (or 5 NAND)



Memory trick **Sum = XOR** ("exactly one 1"), **Carry = AND** ("both 1"): $1 + 1 = 10_2$.

4 Full Adder (FA) high-yield

m	A	B	C_{in}	S	C_{out}
0	0	0	0	0	0
1	0	0	1	1	0
2	0	1	0	1	0
3	0	1	1	0	1
4	1	0	0	1	0
5	1	0	1	0	1
6	1	1	0	0	1
7	1	1	1	1	1

Adds **three** bits: A, B and the carry-in from the previous stage.

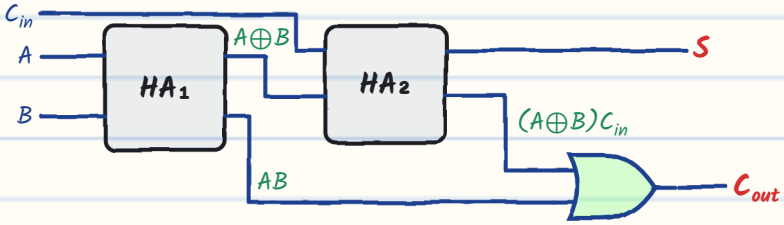
$S = \Sigma m(1, 2, 4, 7)$ → 1 when the number of 1s is **odd**:

$$S = A \oplus B \oplus C_{in}$$

$C_{out} = \Sigma m(3, 5, 6, 7)$ → K-map gives three pairs:

$$C_{out} = AB + BC_{in} + AC_{in}$$

$= AB + C_{in}(A \oplus B)$ (the form used by two half adders) = majority of A, B, C_{in}



FA = two half adders + one OR gate ($C_{out} = C_1 + C_2$)

Circuit	With basic gates	NAND only	NOR only
HA / HS	1 XOR + 1 AND (+1 NOT for HS)	5	5
FA / FS	2 XOR + 2 AND + 1 OR (2 halves + OR)	9	9

5 Half & Full Subtractor

A	B	D	B_0
0	0	0	0
0	1	1	1
1	0	1	0
1	1	0	0

A	B	B_{in}	D	B_{out}
0	0	0	0	0
0	0	1	1	1
0	1	0	1	1
0	1	1	0	1
1	0	0	1	0
1	0	1	0	0
1	1	0	0	0
1	1	1	1	1

Half subtractor (A − B):

$$D = A \oplus B$$

$$B_0 = A'B$$

(borrow only for 0 − 1)

Full subtractor ($A - B - B_{in}$): borrow when $A < B + B_{in}$.

FS = two half subtractors + one OR ($B_{out} = B_1 + B_2$).

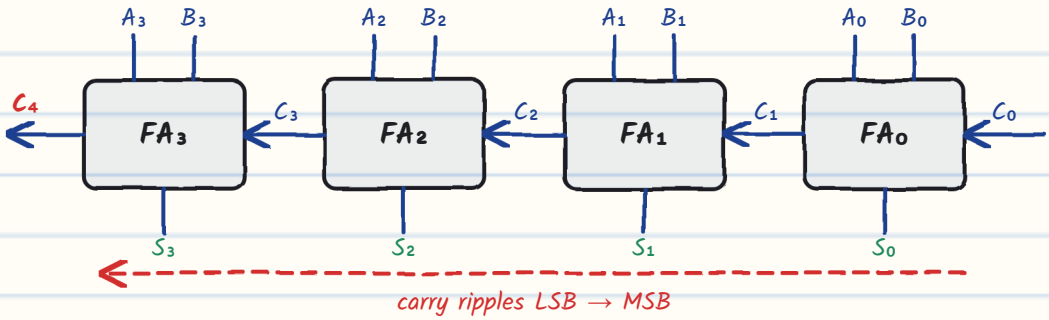
FS: $D = A \oplus B \oplus B_{in} = \Sigma m(1, 2, 4, 7)$ · $B_{out} = \Sigma m(1, 2, 3, 7) = A'B + A'B_{in} + BB_{in} = A'B + B_{in}(A \oplus B)'$

Memory trick Difference = Sum (same XOR). Borrow = carry with **A complemented**: $AB \rightarrow A'B$, $AC_{in} \rightarrow A'B_{in}$.

Exam trap FA = 2 HA + **OR** (not AND). $C_{out} \neq A \oplus B \oplus C_{in}$: that is the sum. HA cannot take a carry-in.

6 Ripple-Carry (Parallel) Adder

Definition An **n-bit parallel adder** chains **n full adders**: each C_{out} feeds the next C_{in} ($C_0 = 0$). All bits are applied at once, but the carry **ripples** from LSB to MSB.



Delay Carry path per stage = 2 gate levels (AND → OR); worst case it passes **all n stages**: $t \approx n \times t_{carry} \approx 2n$ gate delays. 16 bits × 10 ns = **160 ns**.

IC 7483 (newer pinout **74283**): 4-bit binary adder with fast carry; cascade two for 8 bits (C_4 → next C_0).
Cheap (n FAs) but **slow**: delay grows linearly with n.

7 Carry Look-Ahead Adder (CLA) high-yield

Idea Compute every carry **directly from the inputs**, no ripple. Per bit: $G_i = A_iB_i$ (generate: makes a carry itself), $P_i = A_i \oplus B_i$ (propagate: passes C_i on).

Equations $C_{i+1} = G_i + P_iC_i$ · $S_i = P_i \oplus C_i$

$C_1 = G_0 + P_0C_0$

$C_2 = G_1 + P_1G_0 + P_1P_0C_0$

$C_3 = G_2 + P_2G_1 + P_2P_1G_0 + P_2P_1P_0C_0$

$C_4 = G_3 + P_3G_2 + P_3P_2G_1 + P_3P_2P_1G_0 + P_3P_2P_1P_0C_0$

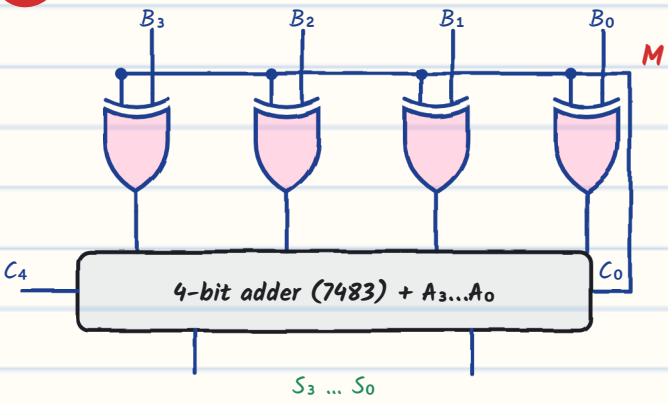
	Ripple	Look-ahead
Carry delay	≈ 2n	**3 (fixed)**
Gates	few	many
Fan-in	2–3	up to n + 1
IC	7483	74182

Worked example ✍️ $A = 1011$, $B = 0101$, $C_0 = 0$ → $G = 0001$, $P = 1110$ · $C_1 = G_0 = 1$, $C_2 = P_1C_1 = 1$, $C_3 = 1$, $C_4 = 1$ (one carry propagated three places, yet all four appear together) · $S = P \oplus C_3C_2C_1C_0 = 1110 \oplus 1110 = 0000$ → **1 0000** (11 + 5 = 16 ✓)

Memory trick **G** = "both 1, I **G**ive a carry" · **P** = "one 1, I **P**ass it on". 3 levels: P/G → AND → OR.

Exam trap CLA delay is fixed only in theory: fan-in grows with n, so real adders use 4-bit CLA blocks + the 74182.

8 4-bit Adder-Subtractor (XOR trick)



Each B_i goes through an XOR with mode line **M**; $C_0 = M$:

M = 0 → $B \oplus 0 = B$, $C_0 = 0$ → $A + B$

M = 1 → $B \oplus 1 = B'$, $C_0 = 1$ → $A + B' + 1 = A - B$ (2's complement)

Signed overflow: $V = C_4 \oplus C_3$

Unsigned: $C_4 = 1$ → $A \geq B$; $C_4 = 0$ → negative result.

Worked example ✍ 7 − 5: 0111 + 1010 + 1 = **1 0010** → 2 (drop C_4) · 5 − 7: 0101 + 1000 + 1 = **0 1110** = −2 · 6 + 5 = 1011: $C_3 = 1$, $C_4 = 0$ → $V = 1$, **overflow**

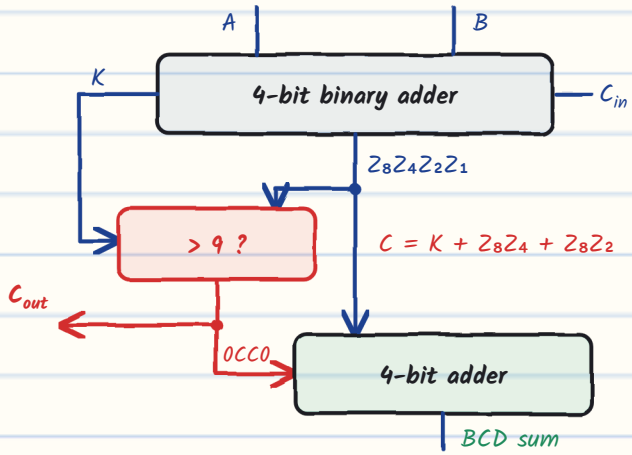
9 BCD Adder

Adds two BCD digits + carry. A 4-bit binary adder gives K $Z_8Z_4Z_2Z_1$ (max 9 + 9 + 1 = 19).

If the sum > 9 (or K = 1), add 0110 (6) to skip the 6 unused codes:

$$C = K + Z_8Z_4 + Z_8Z_2$$

Two 4-bit adders + correction logic (2 AND + 1 OR); C is the decimal carry out.



Worked example ✍ 8 + 7 = 1111 → + 0110 = 1 0101 → **0001 0101** = 15 ✓ · 9 + 9 = 1 0010 (K = 1) → 0010 + 0110 = 1000 → **0001 1000** = 18 ✓ · 4 + 5 = 1001: no correction

10 Magnitude Comparator

A	B	A > B	A = B	A < B
0	0	0	1	0
0	1	0	0	1
1	0	1	0	0
1	1	0	1	0

1-bit: $(A > B) = AB'$ · $(A < B) = A'B$ · $(A = B) = A \odot B$ (XNOR)

4-bit: $x_i = A_i \odot B_i$ · $(A = B) = x_3x_2x_1x_0$

$(A > B) = A_3B_3' + x_3A_2B_2' + x_3x_2A_1B_1' + x_3x_2x_1A_0B_0'$

$(A < B)$: same pattern with $A_i'B_i$. Compare from the **MSB** down.

IC 7485: 4-bit magnitude comparator with cascade inputs (>, =, <); for a single chip tie "=" HIGH. Example: A = 1011, B = 1001 → $x_3 = x_2 = 1$, $A_1B_1' = 1$ → **A > B** (11 > 9 ✓).

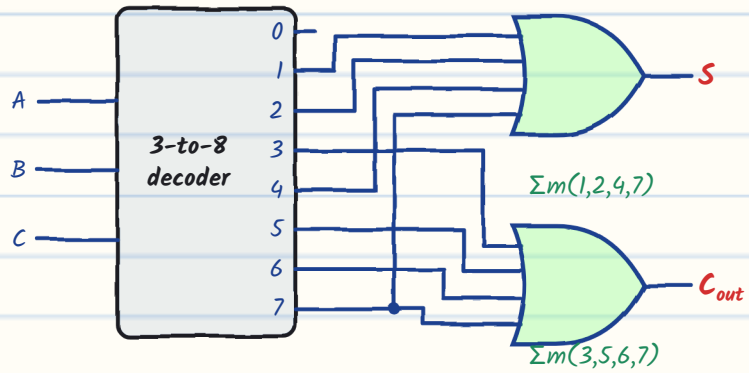
11 Decoder ($n \to 2^n$) high-yield

Definition A decoder converts an n-bit code into 2^n output lines, exactly one active (e.g. memory **chip select**). Each output is one **minterm**, so a decoder is a **minterm generator**.

E	A	B	D_0	D_1	D_2	D_3
0	X	X	0	0	0	0
1	0	0	1	0	0	0
1	0	1	0	1	0	0
1	1	0	0	0	1	0
1	1	1	0	0	0	1

2-to-4 with enable: $D_i = E \cdot m_i$ ($D_0 = EA'B'$ … $D_3 = EAB$). 3-to-8 = 3 NOT + 8 AND.

74138: 3-to-8, active-LOW outputs, enables G1 (high), G2A, G2B (low) · **74139**: dual 2-to-4 · **74154**: 4-to-16 · **7442**: BCD-to-decimal.



full adder = one 3-to-8 decoder + two 4-input OR gates

Any function n-to-2^n decoder + one OR gate per output (OR the minterms). With active-LOW outputs (74138) use a **NAND** gate instead.

Exam trap 4-to-16 from 3-to-8: **2** decoders (A_3 drives the enables). 4-to-16 from 2-to-4: 4 + 1 = **5**.

12 Encoder & Priority Encoder ($2^n \to n$)

Reverse of a decoder. **8-to-3** (octal-to-binary), one input active at a time; just 3 OR gates:

$A_2 = D_4 + D_5 + D_6 + D_7$

$A_1 = D_2 + D_3 + D_6 + D_7$

$A_0 = D_1 + D_3 + D_5 + D_7$

Two faults: D_3 and D_6 together → 111 (wrong); "D_0 active" and "nothing active" both give 000.

Priority encoder: the highest active input wins; **V** (valid) = 1 if any input is active. D_3 highest:

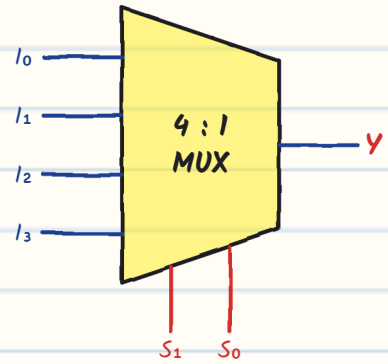
D_0	D_1	D_2	D_3	x	y	V
0	0	0	0	X	X	**0**
1	0	0	0	0	0	1
X	1	0	0	0	1	1
X	X	1	0	1	0	1
X	X	X	1	1	1	1

$x = D_2 + D_3$ · $y = D_3 + D_1D_2'$ · $V = D_0 + D_1 + D_2 + D_3$ · **74148**: 8-to-3 priority encoder (active-LOW, input 7 highest) · **74147**: 10-to-4 (decimal-to-BCD). Use: interrupt priority in a CPU, keyboard encoding.

Memory trick **DE**coder **DE**-compresses: $n \to 2^n$. **EN**coder compresses: $2^n \to n$. The side with more lines is "one-hot".

13 Multiplexer (MUX): Data Selector high-yield

Definition A MUX routes **one of 2^n data inputs** to a single output; **n select lines** choose which. Many-to-one, "data selector", parallel-to-serial converter.



2:1: $Y = S'I_0 + SI_1$

4:1: $Y = S_1'S_0'I_0 + S_1'S_0I_1 + S_1S_0'I_2 + S_1S_0I_3$

4:1 gates: 2 NOT + 4 AND + 1 OR.

Inputs	2	4	8	16	32
Select lines	1	2	3	4	5

ICs: **74151** 8:1 (outputs Y and Y') · **74153** dual 4:1 · **74157** quad 2:1 · **74150** 16:1

→ Implementing a function with a MUX

An n-variable function needs only a $2^{n-1}:1$ MUX: $n-1$ variables drive the selects; each data input is **0, 1, x or x'** (x = last variable). (A 2^n:1 MUX works directly: I_i = the truth-table output, 0 or 1.)

Worked example ✍ $F(A, B, C) = \Sigma m(1, 2, 6, 7)$, 4:1 MUX, $S_1S_0 = AB$

AB	C = 0	C = 1	I
00	0	1	C
01	1	0	C'
10	0	0	0
11	1	1	1

$I_0 \ldots I_3$ = **C, C', 0, 1**

MUX trees 16:1 from 4:1 → 4 + 1 = **5** · 16:1 from 2:1 → 8 + 4 + 2 + 1 = **15** · 8:1 from 2:1 → **7**

2^k:1 from 2:1 MUXes → $2^k - 1$

Memory trick **MUX = many in, one out**: a rotary switch set by the select number. Selects = $\log_2$(inputs).

14 Demultiplexer (DEMUX): Data Distributor

One input D → **one of 2^n outputs**, chosen by n selects. One-to-many, serial-to-parallel.

1:4 → $Y_0 = S_1'S_0'D$, $Y_1 = S_1'S_0D$, $Y_2 = S_1S_0'D$, $Y_3 = S_1S_0D$

A decoder with enable = DEMUX: feed the data into E, the selects into the code inputs. So the **74138** also works as 1:8 DEMUX, and the **74155** is a dual 2-to-4 decoder/DEMUX.

Exam trap A MUX has **1 output**, a DEMUX **1 input**. 16:1 from 4:1 needs 5, not 4. A MUX is a **universal logic module** (any function).

IT link A MUX picks the ALU operand in a CPU; TDM links = MUX + DEMUX.

15 Code Converters

BCD → Excess-3 (XS-3 = BCD + 0011; codes 10–15 are don't-cares). Inputs ABCD (A = MSB), outputs wxyz:

$z = D'$ · $y = CD + C'D' = (C \oplus D)'$

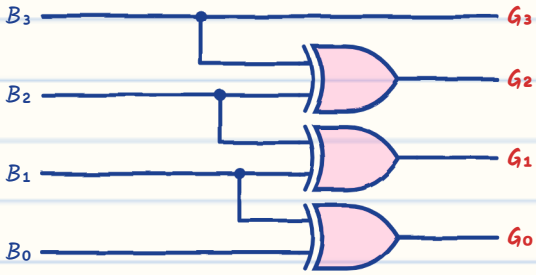
$x = B'C + B'D + BC'D'$ · $w = A + BC + BD$

Check 5 = 0101 → w = BD = 1, x = 0, y = 0, z = 0 → **1000** = 8 ✓

Binary → Gray: $G_3 = B_3$, $G_i = B_{i+1} \oplus B_i$ (n − 1 XORs)

Gray → binary: $B_3 = G_3$, $B_i = B_{i+1} \oplus G_i$ (uses the new B)

1011 → **1110** (Gray) and back: 1, 1⊕1 = 0, 0⊕1 = 1, 1⊕0 = 1 → 1011 ✓



binary → Gray: copy the MSB, XOR neighbours

16 Parity Generator & Checker

Even-parity generator (3-bit message ABC): $P = A \oplus B \oplus C$, so the total number of 1s (with P) is even. Odd parity: $P = (A \oplus B \oplus C)'$.

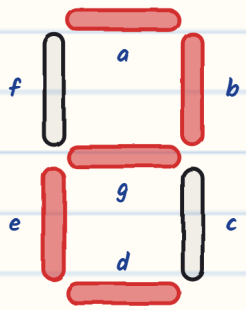
Checker (receiver): $PEC = A \oplus B \oplus C \oplus P$; **0 = OK, 1 = error.**

n bits → n − 1 two-input XOR gates (a "parity tree"). ICs: **74180**, **74280** (9-bit generator/checker).

Example: 101 → P = 0, send 1010; receive 1110 → PEC = 1 → error ✓

Exam trap Parity detects any **odd** number of bit errors, but **not** 2 (or any even number) and it cannot correct (Hamming code can).

17 BCD-to-7-Segment Decoder



digit 2: a b d e g

Digit	0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9
Segments lit	6	**2**	5	5	4	5	6	3	**7**	6

4 BCD inputs → 7 outputs (a–g), one function per segment; codes 10–15 = don't-cares. Segment a is off only for 1 and 4: $a = A + C + BD + B'D'$

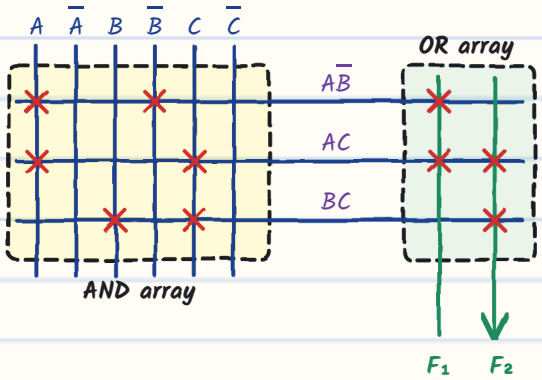
7447: active-LOW (open-collector) outputs → **common-anode** display · **7448**: active-HIGH → **common-cathode** · CMOS: 4511.

Memory trick "**47 is LOW, Anode**": 7447 pulls a segment LOW to light it, so the common pin goes to +V (anode). 7448 is the opposite.

18 ROM, PLA, PAL high-yield

Idea Any SOP = an **AND array** (product terms) feeding an **OR array**. PLDs differ only in **which array is programmable**.

Device	AND array	OR array	Key point
ROM / PROM	fixed (decoder)	**programmable**	all 2^n minterms; stores the truth table as is
PLA	**programmable**	**programmable**	most flexible; product terms **shared**
PAL	**programmable**	fixed	cheaper, faster; no sharing (GAL: erasable)



PLA: × = programmed link; AC is shared

$F_1 = AB' + AC$, $F_2 = AC + BC$: a PLA needs **3** product terms (AC shared); a PAL needs 4.

ROM size $2^n \times m$: $32 \times 8 \rightarrow 5$ address lines, 8 outputs, 256 bits. Full adder = 8 × 2 ROM.

PLA size $n \times k \times m$ (inputs × products × outputs): minimise **distinct product terms**, not literals.

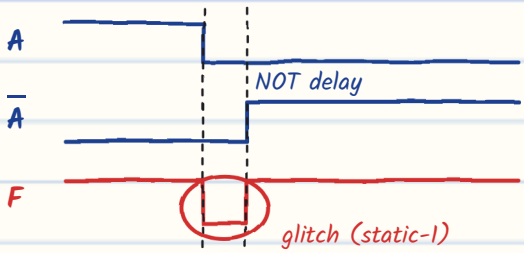
Modern: CPLD, **FPGA** (look-up tables).

Memory trick **ROM**: AND fixed · **PAL**: OR fixed (P-A-L: "**A**ND is programmable, the **L**ast stage is locked") · **PLA**: nothing fixed.

19 Hazards (glitches)

A **hazard** is a momentary wrong output caused by unequal path delays.

- **Static-1:** should stay 1, dips to 0 (SOP)
- **Static-0:** should stay 0, jumps to 1 (POS)
- **Dynamic:** changes 3+ times instead of once



B = C = 1, A falls: F should stay 1

$F = AB + A'C$, $B = C = 1$: when A falls, AB turns off before A'C turns on. **Fix:** add the consensus term **BC** (Boolean Algebra notes, sheet 3), i.e. cover every pair of adjacent 1s by one K-map group.

Exam trap The redundant term a minimal K-map drops is exactly what removes the hazard. Clocked systems sample after outputs settle, so hazards matter most in asynchronous circuits.

Night-Before-the-Exam Sheet

Fact sheet

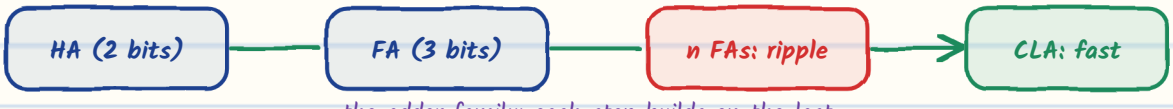
Combinational: $Y = f(\text{present } X)$, no memory
n inputs $\rightarrow 2^n$ truth-table rows
HA: $S = A \oplus B \cdot C = AB$
FA: $S = A \oplus B \oplus C_{in} \cdot C_{out} = AB + C_{in}(A \oplus B)$
HS: $D = A \oplus B \cdot B_o = A'B$
FS: $B_{out} = A'B + A'B_{in} + BB_{in}$
FA = 2 HA + OR · 9 NAND · HA = 5 NAND
Ripple delay $\propto n$ ($\approx 2n$ gate delays)
CLA: $G = AB$, $P = A \oplus B$, $C_{i+1} = G_i + P_i C_i$
Add-sub: $B \oplus M$, $C_0 = M \cdot V = C_4 \oplus C_3$
BCD: add 0110 if $K + Z_8Z_4 + Z_8Z_2$
Comparator: $A = B \Leftrightarrow$ all $x_i = A_i \odot B_i = 1$
Decoder $n \rightarrow 2^n$ · encoder $2^n \rightarrow n$
MUX: 2^n inputs, n selects · DEMUX reverse
n-var function $\rightarrow 2^{n-1}:1$ MUX
Gray: $G_i = B_{i+1} \oplus B_i$ · XS-3 = BCD + 0011
Even parity P = XOR of the data bits
ROM: fixed AND · PAL: fixed OR

→ 74xx ICs to know

IC	Function	IC	Function
7483	4-bit adder (also 74283)	74151	8:1 MUX
74182	look-ahead carry generator	74153	dual 4:1 MUX
74181	4-bit ALU	74157 · 74150	quad 2:1 · 16:1 MUX
7485	4-bit comparator	74155	dual 2-to-4 decoder/DEMUX
74138	3-to-8 decoder, active-LOW	74148	8-to-3 priority encoder
74139 · 74154	dual 2-to-4 · 4-to-16	74147	10-to-4 priority encoder
7442	BCD-to-decimal	7447 · 7448	BCD-to-7-seg (CA · CC)
74180 · 74280	parity gen./checker	4511 (CMOS)	BCD-to-7-seg, CC

Top traps FA = 2 HA + OR (not AND) · difference = sum ($A \oplus B \oplus C$) · 16:1 from 4:1 = 5 · BCD correction is +6, XS-3 is +3 · plain encoder fails with 2 active inputs · 74138 / 7447 outputs are active-LOW · parity misses 2-bit errors

All tricks together Sum = XOR, carry = AND · borrow = carry with A' · G gives, P passes · MUX = many in, one out; selects = $\log_2$(inputs) · DEcoder DE-compresses · "over nine? add six" · 47 is LOW, anode · ROM fixed AND, PAL fixed OR, PLA nothing fixed · Gray: copy MSB, XOR neighbours



the adder family: each step builds on the last

✓ Practice MCQs (exam pattern, 10 marks)

try first, then check

1. The carry output of a half adder is:
(a) $A \oplus B$ (b) $A + B$
(c) $A \cdot B$ (d) $(A \cdot B)'$

2. Select lines of a 32:1 MUX:
(a) 5 (b) 4
(c) 32 (d) 16

3. Minimum 2-input NAND gates for a full adder:
(a) 5 (b) 7
(c) 8 (d) 9

4. Output lines of a decoder with 4 inputs:
(a) 8 (b) 16
(c) 4 (d) 2

5. In a carry look-ahead adder, the generate term G_i is:
(a) $A_i \oplus B_i$ (b) $A_i + B_i$
(c) A_iB_i (d) $(A_iB_i)'$

6. A BCD adder corrects a sum above 9 by adding:
(a) 0011 (b) 0110
(c) 1010 (d) 1001

7. Which IC is an 8-to-1 multiplexer?
(a) 74138 (b) 7485
(c) 7447 (d) 74151

8. Programmable AND + fixed OR array:
(a) PAL (b) PROM
(c) PLA (d) RAM

9. How many 4:1 MUXes make a 16:1 MUX?
(a) 4 (b) 5
(c) 8 (d) 3

10. XOR adder-subtractor, for A − B:
(a) M = 0, C_0 = 0 (b) M = 1, C_0 = 0
(c) M = 1, C_0 = 1 (d) M = 0, C_0 = 1

Answer key → 1-c · 2-a · 3-d · 4-b · 5-c · 6-b · 7-d · 8-a · 9-b · 10-c

Written question Implement $F(A, B, C, D) = \Sigma m(1, 3, 4, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15)$ with an 8:1 multiplexer (A, B, C on the select lines, A = MSB). 8 marks

1. Selects = A, B, C; each data input is 0, 1, D or D' (1)
2. For each ABC, list F at D = 0 and D = 1 (table) (3)
3. (0, 1) → D · (1, 0) → D' · (0, 0) → 0 · (1, 1) → 1, so $I_0 \ldots I_7$ = D, D, D', 0, 0, D, 1, 1 (2)
4. One 74151 + one NOT for D'; check m12: I_6 = 1 ✓ (2)

ABC	D=0	D=1	I
000	0	1	D
001	0	1	D
010	1	0	D'
011	0	0	0
100	0	0	0
101	0	1	D
110	1	1	1
111	1	1	1

→ Before the exam ✓

- ✓ HA, FA, HS, FS tables and equations
- ✓ FA from two HAs and from a decoder
- ✓ CLA carries $C_1 \ldots C_4$; MUX data inputs
- ✓ 7483, 74138, 74151, 7485, 74148, 7447

Also practise (written):
① BCD adder block diagram
② 4-bit comparator equations
③ BCD → XS-3 with K-maps
④ FA with a 3-to-8 decoder